

AXEL WATANABE

Department of Economics
Concordia University
1455, boulevard De Maisonneuve Ouest
Montréal (Québec) H3G 1M8

Phone: (514) 848-2424, ext. 3917
Email: axel.watanabe@concordia.ca
Web: <https://axelmontreal.github.io>

CURRENT POSITION

Associate Professor of Economics
Concordia University, June 2026 – present

PREVIOUS POSITIONS

Assistant Professor of Economics
Concordia University, October 2018 – May 2026

Assistant Professor of Economics
Lamar University, August 2015 – December 2018

Visiting Instructor of Economics
Lamar University, August 2013 – May 2015

Visiting Instructor of Economics
University of Minnesota Duluth, August 2012 – May 2013

EDUCATION

May 2015 Ph.D., Economics, Washington University in St. Louis, MO
May 2007 M.A., Economics, Washington University in St. Louis, MO
Doctoral Program in Economics, Kyoto University, Japan
March 2004 B.A., Economics, Kyoto University, Japan
International Legal Studies Program, Sophia University, Japan

DISSERTATION

Essays on the Size Distribution of Cities:

- Explaining the Size Distribution of Cities: Extreme Economies (joint work with Marcus Berliant)
- A Scale-Free Transportation Network Explains the City-Size Distribution (joint work with Marcus Berliant)
- A Spatial Production Economy Explains Gross Metropolitan Product

Committee: Marcus Berliant (chair), John Nachbar, Sukkoo Kim

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Primary: Urban Economics, Public Finance
- Secondary: Applied Microeconomics

PUBLICATIONS

- “[Agglomeration in Purely Neoclassical and Symmetric Economies](#)” with Marcus Berliant (Washington University in St. Louis). *Regional Science and Urban Economics* **119** (2026), 104–222.
Presented at
 - 14th European Meeting of the Urban Economics Association, Berlin, Germany (March 2025)

- [“Internal Migration and Relocation Aversion”](#)
The Annals of Regional Science 75:28 (2026).
Presented at
 - 13th European Meeting of the Urban Economics Association, Copenhagen, Denmark (June 2024)
 - Midwest Economic Theory and International Trade Conference, Indianapolis, IN (May 2024)
 - RCEA International Conference in Economics, Econometrics and Finance, London, UK (May 2024)
 - 17th North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association, Toronto, Canada (October 2023)
 - 60th Congress of European Regional Science Association, held virtually from Bolzano, Italy (August 2020)
- [“Labor Market and Urban Wage Premium”](#), *Handbook of Labor, Human Resources and Population Economics* (2023).
- [“A Scale-Free Transportation Network Explains the City-Size Distribution”](#) with Marcus Berliant (Washington University in St. Louis), *Quantitative Economics* 9 (2018), 1419–1451.
Presented at:
 - International Transportation Economics Association Annual Conference, Barcelona, Spain (June 2017)
 - 11th World Congress of the Econometric Society, Montréal, QC, Canada (August 2015)
 - 52nd Congress of European Regional Science Association, Bratislava, Slovakia (August 2012)
 - Rimini Conference in Economics & Finance, Toronto, ON, Canada (August 2012)
 - 55th North American Meetings of the Regional Science Association International, New York, NY (November 2008)
- [“Let Tiebout Pick up the Tab: Pricing out Externalities with Free Mobility”](#), *International Journal of Economic Theory* 13.1 (2017), 147–162.
Presented at:
 - 63rd North American Meetings of the Regional Science Association International, Minneapolis, MN (November 2016)
 - Rimini Conference in Economics & Finance, Waterloo, ON, Canada (September 2016)
 - 56th Congress of European Regional Science Association, Vienna, Austria (August 2016)
- [“Explaining the Size Distribution of Cities: Extreme Economies”](#) with Marcus Berliant (Washington University in St. Louis), *Quantitative Economics* 6 (2015), 153–187.
Presented at:
 - American Economic Association Annual Meeting, Atlanta, GA (January 2010)
 - Economics Graduate Student Conference at Washington University in St. Louis, MO (October 2008)
 - Midwest Economic Theory and International Economics Meetings, Urbana-Champaign, IL (May 2008)
 - 54th North American Meetings of the Regional Science Association International, Savannah, GA (November 2007)

WORK IN PROGRESS

- “Geographic Mobility and Spatial Sorting” with Fan-chin Kung (East Carolina University)
- “Geographic Mobility within 11 Nations of the United States”
- “Network Cost of City Location”
- [“A Spatial Production Economy Explains Gross Metropolitan Product”](#)
Presented at:
 - 55th Congress of European Regional Science Association, Lisbon, Portugal (August 2015)
 - 60th North American Meetings of the Regional Science Association International, Atlanta, GA (November 2013)
- “Industrial Diversity vs Robust Industry: The Making of Recession-Proof Cities” with Luiggi Donayre (University of Minnesota Duluth) and Anastasios Kitsos (Plymouth University)

INVITED SEMINARS

- “The Size Distribution of Cities with Distance-Bound Households” at Université du Québec à Montréal (May 2022)

SERVICE AND MEMBERSHIPS

- Referee: Journal of Urban Economics (4), Networks and Spatial Economics (2), Urban Studies (1), Letters in Spatial and Resource Sciences (1), International Journal of Economic Theory (1), Journal of Regional Science (2), PLOS One (1), Economics Letters (1).
- Member: Econometric Society, American Economic Association, Urban Economics Association, Regional Science Association International, European Economic Association, Centre internuniversitaire de recherche en économie quantitative
- Panelist for a public forum “The Economy of Cities: Urban planning and transportation” hosted by 4th Space, Concordia University, 2020
- Research proposal evaluator for German-Israeli Foundation for Scientific Research and Development, 2016
- Economic consulting for a local newspaper, Beaumont Enterprise, 2015-2018
- Faculty Recruiting Committee, Department of Economics and Finance, Lamar University, 2015, and Department of Economics, Concordia University, 2020-2021
- Academic Advisory Board (textbook proposal evaluator), McGraw-Hill
- Organizer for Duluth Diversity Dialogues 2013
- TA Orientation Department Organizer, 2011, 2010
- Teaching Center Graduate-Student Advisory Board, 2011-2012
- Assistant for Decentralization Conference, 2009
- Assistant for Conference on Experimental Social Sciences, 2008

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- Instructor, Concordia University
 - Graduate Urban Economics (Winter 2025, Winter 2024, Winter 2022, Winter 2021, Winter 2020, Winter 2019)
 - Undergraduate Urban Economics (Fall 2025, Fall 2024, Fall 2023, Fall 2022, Fall 2021, Fall 2020, Fall 2019)
 - Intermediate Macroeconomics I (Winter 2026, Fall 2025, Fall 2023, Winter 2023, Fall 2022, Fall 2021, Fall 2020, Winter 2019)
 - Introductory Microeconomics (Winter 2026, Winter 2025, Winter 2024, Winter 2023, Fall 2021, Fall 2020, Fall 2019)
- Instructor, Lamar University
 - Intermediate Macroeconomics (Fall 2013 – Spring 2018)
 - Introductory Microeconomics (Fall 2018, Spring 2018, Fall 2017, Summer 2017, Spring 2017, Fall 2015, Fall 2014, Fall 2013)
 - Introductory Macroeconomics (Fall 2015, Fall 2014, Spring 2014, Fall 2013)
 - Introductory Economics (Fall 2017, Summer 2016, Summer 2015, Summer 2014)
 - Economics for MBA (Spring 2018)
- Instructor, University of Minnesota Duluth
 - Urban Economics (Fall 2012)
 - Labor Economics (Fall 2012)
 - Intermediate Microeconomics (Spring 2013, Fall 2012)
 - Introductory Microeconomics (Spring 2013)
- Instructor, Washington University in St. Louis
 - Urban Economics (Spring 2012, Spring 2011, Summer 2010)
 - Intermediate Microeconomics (Summer 2009, Summer 2008)
 - Introductory Microeconomics (Summer 2011, Summer 2007)
- Teaching Assistant, Washington University in St. Louis
 - Introductory Microeconomics (Fall 2010, Fall 2009, Fall 2006)
 - Industrial Organization (Fall 2008)
 - Urban Economics (Spring 2008)
 - Intermediate Microeconomics (Fall 2007)

- Intermediate Macroeconomics (Spring 2007)
- Teaching Assistant, Kyoto University
 - Graduate Microeconomics (Spring 2005)

GRANTS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND HONORS

- Soutien à la recherche pour la relève professorale (New Researcher Grant), Le Fonds de recherche du Québec – Société et culture, 2020-2023 (2nd place out of 7 applications).
- 40 Under 40 of Southeast Texas honoree, 2017
- Dissertation Fellowship, Washington University in St. Louis, 2009-2010
- Summer Research Fellowship, Washington University in St. Louis, 2008, 2009, 2010
- Graduate Scholarship, Washington University in St. Louis, 2006-2008, 2010-2011
- University Fellowship, Washington University in St. Louis, 2006-2007
- John Stuart Mill Fellowship, Washington University in St. Louis, 2006-2007

SUPERVISION

PH.D. STUDENTS

- Jimmy Cao, Concordia (supervisor)
- Samuel Pichette, Concordia (thesis committee)
- Muntasir Chaudhury, Concordia (thesis committee)
- Ribal Abi Raad, Concordia (thesis committee)

MA STUDENTS

- Joshua Calvin Koa, Concordia (supervisor)
- Emma Gunther, Concordia (supervisor)
- Luther Edson, Concordia (second reader/examiner)
- Reza Roubari, Concordia (second reader/examiner)
- Kaiyi Kuang, Concordia (second reader/examiner)
- Nigel McKernan, Concordia (second reader/examiner)
- Zheshu Yang, Concordia (second reader/examiner)

LANGUAGES AND COMPUTER SKILLS

- Languages: English (fluent), French (CEFR level B2/upper intermediate) and Japanese (fluent)
- Software: MATLAB, L^AT_EX and Eclipse.

REFERENCES

Marcus Berliant
 Phone: (314) 935-8486
 Cell: (314) 566-5114
berliant@wustl.edu

Sukko Kim
 Phone: (314) 935-4961
soks@wustl.edu

John Nachbar
 Phone: (314) 935-5612
nachbar@wustl.edu

Bruce Petersen
 Phone: (314) 935-5643
petersen@wustl.edu

The mailing address for all references above is Department of Economics, Washington University in St. Louis, MSC 1208-228-308, One Brookings Dr., St. Louis, MO 63130-4899, USA

© Last updated in May 2026.